CHESTER CIRCUIT

CHESHIRE

COUNTY GAOL, CHESTER CASTLE

This castle is the property of the king. The first room is a hall: there are two staircases leading up from it to four rooms for master's-side debtors. Down eighteen steps is a small court, which was common to debtors and felons. It is lately divided, but the high close pales which separate the two courts, now so very small, deprive both debtors and felons of the benefit of fresh air, and the keeper has no view of the felons' court or day-room, in which men and women are together: the debtors, in the pope's kitchen (improperly called their free ward, as they pay one shilling a week each); the felons, in their day-room, the king's kitchen. Both these are six steps below the court: each of them about thirty-five feet by twenty-two. Near the former is the condemned room. Under the king's kitchen is the king's cellar; quite useless. Under the pope's kitchen is a dark passage twenty-four feet by nine: the descent to it, is by twenty-one steps from the court. No window: not a breath of fresh air: only two apertures (lately made) with grates in the ceiling into the pope's kitchen above. On one side of it are six cells (stalls) each about seven and a half feet by three, with a barrack-bedstead, and an aperture over the door about eight inches by four. In each of these are locked up at night, sometimes three or four felons. They pitch these dungeons two or three times a year: when I was in one of them, I ordered the door to be shut; and my situation brought to mind what I had heard of the Black Hole at Calcutta.

The felons' day-room is not secure. They escaped in 1775, by breaking through the slight floor into the king's cellar below; and through the decayed walls of that they made their way down the hill. The keeper, who is careful and humane, was not blameable.

The present constable is Mr. Ferdinando Gillio, a surgeon in London. He obliges the gaoler to pay rent £30 a year, and

takes himself the salary of £18 5s. od., the gaoler paying the tax of £2 13s. od. thereon. I need hardly mention the impropriety of one receiving the salary, and another doing the duty.[1]

CHESTER CITY BRIDEWELL

In the keeper's house there is a room or two for those that can pay for a bed; and there is now built a workshop and a room over it twenty-five feet by sixteen and a half. The employment is spinning. Down ten steps are two new dungeons. No water: no alllowance: clauses against spirituous liquors not hung up. Keeper's salary, £4 4s. od.

Here were several leaden weights marked 30, 40, 60 pounds, with a ring and chains to each: these are fastened, as the magistrates order, or the keeper finds needful, to the legs of refractory prisoners, so that they cannot walk without carrying the weight. The keeper said that it was extremely difficult to make prisoners behave orderly, while they were kept together.

[1] I have in three of my visits seen the place of confinement for deserters in this castle, who are not under the care of the gaoler, but of the invalids of the garrison. It is a bad, unhealthy cell, often productive of the gaol-fever; a room should be appropriated to the sick, for the surgeon told me he could not attend them there. An officer at Worcester informed me, that having sent a sergeant and two men for two deserters lodged here, three of them died a few days after they came to their quarters, and he had them buried privately, without military honours, to the surprise of the soldiers, who knew not the reason.